

Global Initiative to Improve Access to Mpox Vaccines - WHO

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A global initiative to establish a stockpile of mpox vaccines was launched on 27 August, creating a long-term mechanism to ensure countries have access to vaccines when responding to mpox outbreaks.

Set to begin operations later this month, this new global mpox vaccine stockpile that all countries can access is a resource that was approved by the Board of Gavi, the Vaccine Alliance (Gavi) in 2025, and is funded by Gavi and coordinated by the International Coordinating Group (ICG) on Vaccine Provision. The ICG partners are the International Federation of Red Cross and Red Crescent Societies (IFRC), Médecins Sans Frontières (MSF), the United Nations Children's Fund (UNICEF) and the World Health Organization (WHO).

The initiative builds on the Access and Allocation Mechanism established in 2024 during the last mpox Public Health Emergency of International Concern (PHEIC), and will ensure that countries have timely and equitable access to vaccines for outbreak response.

Mpox continues to cause outbreaks globally, with two-thirds of reported cases occurring in the African Region. From 1 January 2022 to 31 July 2026, 145 countries and territories reported 190 683 confirmed cases and 529 deaths. Mpox is a viral disease that spreads primarily through close physical contact between people, while animal-to-human transmission continues to occur in parts of Africa, contributing to the ongoing risk of new outbreaks. Mpox can cause severe disease, especially in children and people with suppressed immune systems. By protecting people at risk of infection and severe disease, vaccines help contain mpox outbreaks more quickly, prevent severe illness and save lives.

<https://Awww.who.int/news/item/02-09-2026-global-initiative-launched-to-improve-access-to-mpox-vaccines>

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Quotes from partners:

Dr Sania Nishtar, CEO of Gavi, the Vaccine Alliance, said: "During the 2022 mpox outbreak, lower-income countries were left behind when it came to access to vaccines and it was clear that a mechanism was needed to ensure this global public good could be accessed by those who need it most. Core to the Gavi Leap approach is increasing our responsiveness to country needs, and the bottom line is that any country in the world - not just those with the

ability to pay the most - should be able to use this tool to save lives. That is why Gavi supported the international response to the 2024 global mpox emergency by securing rapid access to doses through our First Response Fund, and why our Board agreed to establish and finance a global stockpile managed by our ICG partners. Our hope is that this stockpile will keep the world safer from the threat of this deadly disease."

Jagan Chapagain, Secretary General and CEO of the IFRC, said: "Mpox is a horrible illness so I'm pleased that we've got to this important step in the battle to control it. Access to vaccines - for all who need them - is absolutely vital. That's why this global coordination mechanism and vaccine stockpile matters. Both will help ensure vaccines reach the people and communities at greatest risk - when and where they are needed most. This is rare good news."

Dr Daniela Garone, International Medical Coordinator, MSF, said: "MSF welcomes the establishment of a global mpox vaccine stockpile under the International Coordinating Group (ICG) on Vaccine Provision, a mechanism that allows for the equal allocation of vaccines as based on demand and impact in controlling disease outbreaks. The distinctive nature of mpox, with the coexistence of different variants that affect different populations, now demands a close collaboration between country, regional and global mechanisms as well as between disease programmes, health managers, communities and public health partners to reach more people with mpox vaccines."

Catherine Russell, UNICEF Executive Director, said: "Mpox can be devastating for children - not just its physical effects, but also the stigma, interrupted learning, and fear that can come with being isolated from family and friends. This vital initiative will help us quickly get vaccines to the children, families, and communities most at risk of the disease."

Dr Tedros Adhanom Ghebreyesus, WHO Director-General, said: "The launch of a stockpile of mpox vaccines is an important step towards a more sustainable and equitable approach to mpox outbreak response. By establishing a dedicated global stockpile, using an approach that has proven successful for managing other emergency vaccines, we are ensuring that countries can access them more quickly when they need them, saving lives and containing outbreaks before they spread further."

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Note to editors

Mpox

Mpox is a viral illness that spreads mainly through close physical contact, including sexual contact. The disease can be debilitating and disfiguring, affecting men, women and children in different contexts, and can, in some cases, lead to severe complications and

death. WHO Mpox factsheet

International Coordinating Group (ICG) on Vaccine Provision

The ICG was established in 1997, following major outbreaks of meningitis in Africa, as a mechanism to manage and coordinate the provision of emergency vaccine supplies and antibiotics to countries during major outbreaks. Although the occurrence of outbreaks is often unpredictable, further disease spread can be controlled by timely vaccination.

The core mandate of the ICG is to make available and ensure equitable access to licensed vaccines for cholera, meningitis, yellow fever, and Ebola virus disease during outbreaks.

The ICG mechanism seeks to ensure timely and targeted deployment of vaccines so that they can be used effectively in emergency settings where they are most needed.

The ICG manages the global emergency vaccine stockpiles and, working with partners, donors, and manufacturers, determines their size and composition with the goal of ensuring that adequate stocks of emergency supplies are accessible for emergency response.

In 2024, WHO and partners created the ad hoc Access and Allocation Mechanism for mpox vaccines. The longer term ICG will continue the work initiated under the AAM.

In 2025, the Gavi Board formally approved the establishment and financing of the global mpox vaccine stockpile. under the long-standing ICG mechanism to include mpox.

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